



AT THE KREMLIN President Putin talking to the India Today TV team of Anjana Om Kashyap and Geeta Mohan (left); with Editor-in-chief Aroon Purie and Executive Editor-in-chief Kalli Purie

goods. In fact, sanctions in some sectors have proved to be a boon to the Russian economy, spurring a version you could call Atmanirbhar Russia, where local enterprises have stepped up to fill the gaps. Russia is also known to be a highly patriotic nation, whose people, because of their history, are willing to bear great hardship. A lethal combination that one can underestimate only at their own risk. It is often said that Putin's motivation is to expand Russia into other countries to restore the glory of the old Soviet Union. He categorically denies that, saying, "In today's circumstances, it makes no sense."

From Afghanistan and Gaza to AI, Gen-Z unrest, and the disintegration of the Soviet Union, Putin sketched his worldview: a mix of grievance and ambition, historical narrative and hard realpolitik, anchored in the belief that Western dominance is fading and that countries like India will shape what comes next. In a one-on-one, I asked the Russian president whether he had any regrets lingering from his 25-year reign. He mulled over that for a while, his piercing blue eyes never blinking once, and then said: "I don't look back." Perhaps he's a man who doesn't like to admit mistakes. But everything suggests he's very aware of the past, and that's why he can mould the future. For us at INDIA TODAY, it is a privilege that Putin chose us to give his first print interview to an Indian publication when he came to power in Russia in 2000 and now, 25 years later, he has chosen us again to give his first in-depth interview to a private television channel at a critical moment in world affairs. This speaks not just to our editorial credibility but also to the unique position India holds in Putin's calculus. He sees it as a trusted interlocutor, a strategic partner, and perhaps one of the few countries whose media he believes will give him a fair hearing, free of the filter of Western antagonism.

Whether you view Putin as a strategic genius or a dangerous autocrat, his actions and decisions do have profound implications for the world order. India, caught between its historical ties with Russia and its deepening partnership with the West, must navigate these turbulent waters with deft diplomacy. As Putin himself acknowledged, Modi is not someone who succumbs to pressure easily. That independence of thought and action will be India's greatest asset in the years ahead.

You may agree or disagree with Putin, but the candid, well-reasoned counterpoint to the world he offers here is essential reading. Because understanding how the other side sees the world is the first step towards shaping a future that works for all. In a world of echo chambers and ideological rigidity, conversations like these matter. They remind us that dialogue, however difficult, is always preferable to silence, and that even the most controversial deserve to be heard, if only so we can better understand the forces shaping the world.



(Aroon Purie)